Harriet

By Elena Passarello

Portray the character of Harriet with tortoise mannerisms.

HARRIET: (Pg 85) When the HMS Beagle drops her anchor in 1935, get under the biggest frond in sight as fast as you can. Dozens of hungry sailors will jump ship, spears in hand, many lancing their first turpin within minutes. Others will follow the highway of tracks to the higher points of the island, where hill-dwelling turpin grow longer, saltier necks. In a few hours, they'll all trudge back to ship, hefting dozens of your kinds in makeshift stretchers of oars and canvas. Three men to every heavy shell.

Tuck yourself in, little girl. Be still. Don't hiss. There's not enough meat under your dinner-plate shell to merit the tedious chore of turpin gutting.

INTRODUCTION

With a face that everyone fell head over heels for, a pair of bright eyes that had seen more than we will ever know and the most affectionate and gentle nature, Harriet stole hearts every day. She passed away peacefully on June 23, 2006, leaving behind countless admirers and an impressive, unforgettable life. From an unrequited love affair with Charles Darwin himself to heartbreak at Steve "Crocodile Hunter" Irwin's Australian Zoo, Harriet was 175 years old at the time of her death. She weighed 330 pounds and was roughly the size of a dinner table. This is her story, and what a story it is . . .

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HARRIET: (Pg 85-94) And then, a set of lighter steps. A pair of clean pants, a slight cough: the "Ship Nauralist" . . . Charlie *(Charles Darwin)* He'll clear away the brush, pick you up in his small, soft hands. "Tortise," he'll call you, not "turpin." *(mouth closed, taps tongue twice and hiss)* ***How fancy.***

He will name you "Harry," but some part of him knows you're all woman. His delicate touch, as he flips you and runs his fingers along your soft, salty underbelly. Delight in how he hand-feeds you pink flowers. Back in the cabin, he will sketch you by lamplight. He will coax your neck from the shell and tickle it, measure it, memorize it, muttering "Amazing." Try to whisper back to him – ***Charlie***.

You were a catch. Nothing he could find in Africa or

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the West Indies, and certainly not in England. When he eyes your unique shell, a wildness stirs in him.

As the sailors plow through the other tortoises on the Beagle – sometimes 3 adults every day – rest easy. They'll slice each neck in one blow, gulping the gallons of fresh water that spill from each gullet. But remember Charlie's promise to take you away from all this. Sure, he joins the crew in sipping your old neighbor at dinnertime, but he's doing it to keep you safe, to not arouse suspicions. You're not dinner; you're different.

Captain FitzRoy thought he'd hired a seminarian-turned-science-man to prove the world made in seven days. A few nights with you, however, and Charlie's become a charlatan. They fight, but Charlie leaves you out of it. Instead they talk finches:

FITZROY: The islands are as old as Genesis.

CHARLIE: No, these islands are young and as they multiply, the finches change their beaks to serve it.

FITZROY: Serve an island, not our God?

HARRIET: If we can adapt to an ever-changing island,

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who says we can't adapt for love. Adaptations, after all, are nothing more than labor: fueled by chemistry, successful only when lauded by a mate. It's always something love-born. For we were not born to mate and die. We were not born to duplicate the image God threw together long ago. We were born to surprise God as we catch up to the morphing rocks and malleable seas on our own volition.

You finally land in England a year later. Boxes of corpses – birds, plants, bugs, rocks – pass through his study. No tortoises. You were the only one he thought to keep, the remains of the others heaved overboard with the slop.

But that fall, in the draftiest room of the British Museum, you'll find yourself shivering on a table with three other girls your age. All from the Beagle, four secrets stashed away in the gentlemen's cabins. Even godly Captain FitzRoy had a Galapagos on the sly.

DICK: *(tucks her head into her shell and weeps)* I've been out in the garden since October. He took a wife the

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week we docked. A wife!

TOM: At least he doesn't have kids yet. His brats use me for pony rides.

HARRIET: John Gray, the museum's Keeper of Zoology, declares your lot too young to assess scientifically.

JOHN: Sorry, Charlie. Maybe in thirty, forty years. But these finch specimens – yes!

HARRIET: Charlie turns away and faces the bird box on the opposite table. *(to Charlie)* Oh, God, wait for me, Charlie. I'll grow faster. I know I can figure something out. *(to audience)* He'll move you in with his doped-up brother and wed his nervous, pious cousin, devoting his days either to her or the finches. He takes her in a carriage and brand-new hat to the Zoological Society of London, but hides you in a hatbox and in his cheap "B Notbook" he wouldn't dare be seen with in public. Instead of words like "marry," "companion," he write you words like "specimen."

Soon wifey will banish you and the other mistresses to Whitehall where London's gales freeze you into a state of perpetual hibernation. Tom dies. Surely

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somebody will see you're sick and get you the hell out of there – away from her, from him, from that notebook that has changed him so.

GEORGE: *(wheezing)* You're better off without him. Those scientific types are all the same – emotional incapable of seeing past their own needs. They're only married to their work. Damn freak.

HARRIET: When George sleeps, you stare at the initials the whaler carved in her shell. Within a year, she's dead. And all the talk is of Charlie – visitors, botanist, apprentices. His book, his finches, his revolution. And eventually his last words.

CHARLIE: I am not the least afraid to die.

HARRIET: *(bitterly)* Not, "my love" or even "my notebook" or -- God be merciful – "my tortoise." Wickham, the new captain of the Beagle takes you to Australia's Brisbane Botanic Gardens. So that's it, babe. You're forty years shy of middle age and it's over. It's 1893 and Dick, the ol' girl from the Beagle is the only other tortoise left. Three floods in 13 days. Mines explode. Bridges collapse.

DICK: If this keeps up, they'll start eating us again.

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HARRIET: Around you, strange things in dirty pens: a muskrat with swim fins who lays leathery eggs in the mud *(beaver),* a huge dog that hops and keeps its pups in a furry pocket *(kangaroo),* a hissing dog with the teeth of a tiger *(wolf).* And in the center of it all, Master Fleay, another naturalist born a century after Charlie, and the first to give you a lady's name.

FLEAY: *(giving a tour)* I've saved the best for last. Isn't she a beyoot? Harriet is her name. Used to belong to Darwin, she did, back in the last century. But now she is mine, all mine.

*****flash forward*****

HARRIET: A dry field with a fence. The sun is relentless; the women wear trousers and no hats. Many of them sport square, beetle-black faces with one shiny eye. *(camera)* When the eyes blink, it makes daytime lightning. A fully grown man in short pants, named Irwin, hops to either side of you, his hair stuck to his forehead in wet, blond drips.

STEVE IRWIN: *(posing for pictures with Harriet)* Crikey! *(a different pose)* Crikey!

HARRIET: He holds a few poses for the crowd and their

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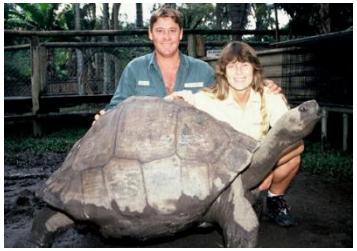
flashing eyeballs, hugging your neck, straddling you with outstretched arms and mouth open wide.

STEVE IRWIN:*(singing)* Happy birthday, dear Harry-ette!

HARRIET: At the edge of the pen, his long-haired wife grits her teeth. He skips over to the "Croco-seum" for an impromptu reptile freak-out. Watch him bound onto the stage, a baby croc in each hand, shaking them like maracas in the dusty breeze. Irwin tosses you a few pink flowers and the grimacing wife cuts a huge cake. She slices through your name as well as your age – the cause for all this celebrating. The number in icing read 1 – 7 – 5.

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